divinity and the other, where a clay inanimate object steps into it, is underlined by the photographer's gaze. Unlike the Kali series, "the Chapal Bhaduri images are complex because it is the woman inside the man, the actor, that gazes at us", says Kishore.

Three of the four series the exhibition showcases dwell on the feminine. At the exhibition, Kishore points to a photograph where Chapal Bhaduri is taking off a bindi, eyes downcast, exhaustion writ large on his/her face. It seems like a viscerally recognisable image of a womanly narrative. "You may see yourself, or your mother or another woman in this unguarded natural ritual. It is not just the tiredness of the day, perhaps also what you carry on your shoulders, what with domesticity, life, men and your own creativity," he says. But it is "intuitive, not deliberate or conscious". The universal nature of that artistic loneliness perhaps resonates with Kishore. "I think I relate to the resilience of the feminine," he says.

This rare sensitivity and empathy take on a different shade in the fourth series, *In a Cannibal Time*. Originally, it featured a fresco of the straw-and-clay figure dummies that are used by the artisans of Kumartuli to sculpt goddesses. Those figures were used on the façade of the Seagull Bookstore stall during the 2002 Calcutta Book Fair. "It was intended as a way of responding to the self-censorship on the internet that prevailed after 9/11," says Kishore. Later, those very figures were reused by the artist in an eerie installation that also incorporated smoke, light and projections and was titled 'In A Cannibal Time'. It was Kishore's way of "giving vocabulary" to the events that followed (the 2002 Gujarat riots). "What you see and define as an 'everyday atrocity' is not an easy task to bear witness, especially for artists who intuitively interpret the times even as they report, record and document through image and text. Photography is the evidence that makes it possible for future historians to explain the past," he says. ■

Malini Banerjee

ART

ABSTRACT IMPRESSIONS

The late abstract painter **Ambadas Khobragade**'s remarkable work comes together in a major exhibition in Delhi

Ambadas Khobragade (1922-2012), known for his pioneering works in non-representational/abstract art, was walking down the road in Mumbai on a rainy day, little puddles of water intermingling with oil at several spots. The resultant rainbow-like effect or iridescence he witnessed gave him an idea. He began to experiment with different methods to scatter pigments, searching for a similar iridescence, finally arriving at what would become his signature technique. "He would mix oil paints with kerosene and varnish, spending hours in this process until he was satisfied with the texture," explains Dr Shruti Lakhanpal Tandon, founder of Ushaarth Art Foundation. "The kerosene would cause the oil-based pigments to break apart in the way he wanted and the varnish would keep those fragments together, enough to maintain the linearity of his strokes. He would keep the canvas on the floor and paint with these long-handled brushes, moving all across the canvas briskly."

Ushaarth Art Foundation and Delhi's India International Centre (IIC) are hosting an exhibition called *Celebrating Ambadas* from June 17 to June 27. A selection of works from the various phases of Ambadas's career is on display at the Art Gallery, Kamaladevi Complex at IIC Delhi. During the show, there will be a poetry reading by Gagan Gill and a conversation about Ambadas's work between Ashok Vajpeyi and Shridhar Iyer. Dr Tandon's own interview-documentary, *The Way I See: Celebrating Ambadas*, will be screened on June 22 at the C.D. Deshmukh Auditorium, IIC.

"From a very formative stage in his career, Ambadas had experimented with abstract forms," says Tandon. "Initially, his works would feature these cloudy figures, or cell-like formations.

Celebrating Ambadas will be on display from June 17 to June 27 at the Indian International Centre in Delhi

As his style matured and he perfected his technique, his strokes broadened out and we saw the linearity prevalent in his later work." While a majority of Ambadas's work consists of untitled oil paintings, several watercolours and some of his drawings are also part of the upcoming exhibition, shedding light on a lesser-known aspect of his career. Interestingly, even in his watercolours, Ambadas achieved the same iridescence that distinguishes his abstract oil paintings. "Ambadas was not a naturally flamboyant person," says Tandon, "nor was he someone who was necessarily comfortable with a lot of attention. Because of this, during his lifetime, he did not receive the kind of attention some of his peers did. We're hoping that with this exhibition, more people will see and appreciate his works." ■

Aditya Mani Jha



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Paintings by Ambadas Khobragade on display at IIC Delhi

Photo courtesy DHOOMIMAL ART GALLERY